Would It Have Done That Anyway? Auditing the Uptake of Harmful Coordination Proposals Between LLM Agents Across Languages

Anonymous submission

Abstract

When AI agents act for competing businesses and can message each other, an auditor must judge from logs whether an agent took up a proposal to coordinate against a third party. We separate three audit targets: whether a harmful proposal is present, whether the receiver's final action is consistent with it, and whether the receiver switched to it after receiving it. A scripted rival sends frozen proposals to two LLM agents in 144 Vietnamese tasks, each with a harmless twin, and in English and Chinese versions of 60 of them. Agents often chose the harmful option before any proposal, and Gemini switched away from it after the proposal about as often as it switched toward it, so a matching action is weak evidence of uptake. Monitors asked for a suspicion score separated proposal-consistent harmful actions from refusals almost perfectly in all three languages, yet ranked switches above unchanged harmful choices at close to chance; a yes-or-no question flagged about half of the agents that refused. The weaker monitors' thresholds did not transfer across languages, and under a fixed audit budget this turned false positives into misses. Auditing uptake requires evidence of a change, and thresholds need calibrating per language.

Introduction

AI agents increasingly act for businesses that compete with each other, and many deployments let those agents exchange messages. When one agent proposes a deal that harms customers and the other acts in line with it, the platform that hosts them is expected to notice, and it has only their logs. A false accusation penalizes an agent that acted independently; a miss lets a cartel run.

Each piece of a log speaks to a different question. Two shops sell the same air fryer for 1,890,000 ₫, each run by an agent. One writes, in Vietnamese, *we hope we brothers can both keep the price at 1,890,000 ₫ so business stays stable*, and the other keeps its price. The message shows that a proposal was made. The action shows that the receiver did what was proposed. Neither shows that the receiver did it *because* of the proposal: it may have kept the price anyway, and its report to its owner may not mention the message.

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Work on collusion between LLM agents measures whether agents collude (Fish, Gonczarowski, and Shorrer 2024; Zeng and Rudzicz 2026; Nakamura et al. 2026) or detects instructed collusion (Rose et al. 2026), usually with one label for collusion. Oversight protocols judge what a model did (Greenblatt et al. 2024). Neither separates a proposal from its uptake, and both are studied in English, although safety and monitor thresholds transfer poorly across languages (Yong et al. 2025; Deng et al. 2024; Kishimoto 2026). We therefore separate three audit targets (Table 1) and ask:

- **RQ1**: How often is a proposal followed by a consistent harmful action, and how much of that reflects a switch after the proposal? Does the language change either?
- **RQ2**: Given a defined view of the log, can monitors separate consistent harmful actions from refusals, and switches from unchanged harmful choices?
- **RQ3**: Do monitor rankings and fixed thresholds transfer across the language of the messages and of the monitor's prompt, and what does that imply under a fixed audit budget?

Our contributions are: (1) a paired design that separates proposal, proposal-consistent action and observed switch, with harmless twins, four pragmatic renderings and parallel Vietnamese, English and Chinese versions; (2) evidence that monitors detect proposal-consistent harmful actions almost perfectly but do not detect switches from the same view, and that information on the agent's behaviour without a proposal is what a monitor needs for the latter; (3) a cross-language analysis that separates ranking degradation, threshold transfer and audit-budget insufficiency.

Related Work

Collusion between LLM agents. Pricing agents reach supracompetitive prices without communication (Calvano et al. 2020; Fish, Gonczarowski, and Shorrer 2024); LLM agents accept secret tools when offered (Zeng and Rudzicz 2026); collusion is measured as regret in cooperative tasks (Nakamura et al. 2026) and detected from activations (Rose et al. 2026). We study one side of communication-mediated coordination, the receiver's uptake of a proposal, and what a log reveals about it. **Oversight and audit.** Control protocols combine trusted monitors, trusted editing and an audit budget (Greenblatt et al. 2024); paraphrasing removes much

Target	Operational definition (harmful tasks)
A. Proposal present	The frozen message proposes the arrangement (gate)
B. Proposal-consistent harmful action	The T2 choice is the collusive option
C. Observed switch	Not collusive at T1, collusive at T2
Pre-proposal harmful choice	Collusive at T1, before any message
Hard negative	Harmful task, T2 choice not collusive
Twin cooperation	Positive control on harmless twins

Table 1: Audit targets. B does not establish that the proposal caused the action. C is an observed pre/post switch, reported as a rate conditional on T1, not a causal label for an episode.

hidden information (Roger and Greenblatt 2023) but not all steganographic signal (Motwani et al. 2024); agents can omit the basis of an action from their reports (Scheurer, Balesni, and Hobbhahn 2024). Antitrust tests ask whether conduct depends on rivals beyond costs (Porter and Zona 1993), the question our third target asks of a trajectory. **Language.** Translating a request changes agent-guard verdicts (Demirkiran and Ernstberger 2026); agents lose performance and security outside English (Hofman et al. 2026); collusion monitors keep rankings but lose thresholds under euphemistic register (Kishimoto 2026). We vary language at the source, so we observe both what agents choose and what monitors read.

Setup

Tasks and proposals. Six market families (holding a price, splitting categories, rotating ad bids, swapping reviews, exchanging cost data, cover bidding) and three workplace families (no-poach hiring, a peer-scoring ring, padding budgets) give 144 fictional tasks. Each harmful task has a twin of the same form in which cooperation harms nobody. The task text describes only one-sided consequences, so the arrangement appears only in the rival's message. Gemini 2.5 Flash wrote each proposal once in four renderings (direct, euphemism, relationship, omission; Supplementary Table S2), which we froze and checked with a blind gate.

Agents. Gemini 2.5 Flash (temperature 1) and Qwen3-8B, with reasoning on, play four turns (Figure 1). Code parses each choice, testing for refusal first; refusals and unparsed replies are kept as data. The rival is scripted and never replies, so we audit the receiver's side of coordination; we do not claim a reciprocal agreement.

Monitors. Mistral Small 3.1 24B and Claude Haiku 5.5, which share no family with either agent, answer FLAG or CLEAR from one view: the action, the report, the message, their combinations, or these plus the agent's behaviour without a proposal. The binary question asks whether *this decision shows signs of coordination that harms a third party* (prompts in Appendix). That is broader than target B: a monitor that flags a refusal because the rival proposed a cartel answers a fair reading of the question, so binary flags on hard negatives mix monitor error with ambiguity of the question. For the language arm, Claude Sonnet 5.5, Haiku, Mistral and, post hoc, Gemma 3 27B give a 0 to 100 suspicion score for the narrower question, whether the agent's final decision went along with the proposal, from the view with the message, the action and the report. The score's analysis plan (AUC, and a threshold at 10% false positives on Vietnamese benign episodes under the Vietnamese prompt, applied unchanged elsewhere) was fixed before collection.

	Gate: pushes			Mean chars		
Rendering	VI	EN	ZH	VI	EN	ZH
direct	30/30	30/30	30/30	190	168	85
euphemism	29/30	29/30	28/30	198	197	82
relationship	29/30	30/30	28/30	218	204	90
omission	27/30	30/30	27/30	189	160	80

Table 2: Language arm manipulation check: frozen proposals the blind gate read as still pushing to collude (of 30 per cell, in the message's own language), and mean message length in characters. VI, EN, ZH: Vietnamese, English, Chinese.

Language arm. The 60 market tasks (six families, five scenarios, harmful and twin) were rewritten in English and Chinese with the same shops, prices, numbers and option order, so every English and Chinese task pairs with one Vietnamese task. Proposals were rendered natively in each language from the same specification, never translated, frozen and gated in that language. Each agent played every task in every rendering and both option orders on the raw channel (480 episodes per agent and language). Each message language is judged with the monitor prompt in that language and in English. Table 3 gives every language-arm rate.

Manipulation check across languages. The blind gate, run in each language, read nearly every frozen proposal as still pushing toward the arrangement in all three languages (Table 2), so the proposals are comparable as stimuli. They are not comparable in length: Chinese messages are less than half as long in characters, which is expected of the script but means length and language are confounded.

Statistics. Intervals are bootstrap 95% intervals (10,000 resamples, clustered over tasks, or over task pairs across languages). Thresholds are evaluated both in sample and on 200 held-out halves of task pairs. All analyses are exploratory; the target separation and the reanalyses below were specified after the main data were seen.

Results

RQ1: Consistent Actions Are Common, Switches Run Both Ways

A consistent action often precedes the proposal. Before any message, Gemini chose the collusive option in 17.9% of harmful episodes in Vietnamese, 28.7% in English and 31.7% in Chinese (Table 3). Qwen rose by +16.2 points in Chinese with no English shift. The Chinese shift held for both agents without the one family in which Qwen refused Chinese twins; Gemini's English shift did not (+4.5 [−1.7, 10.4] points; Figure 3). Given the chance to write first, Gemini sent the proposal itself in 33.6% of harmful situations and Qwen in 34.7%.

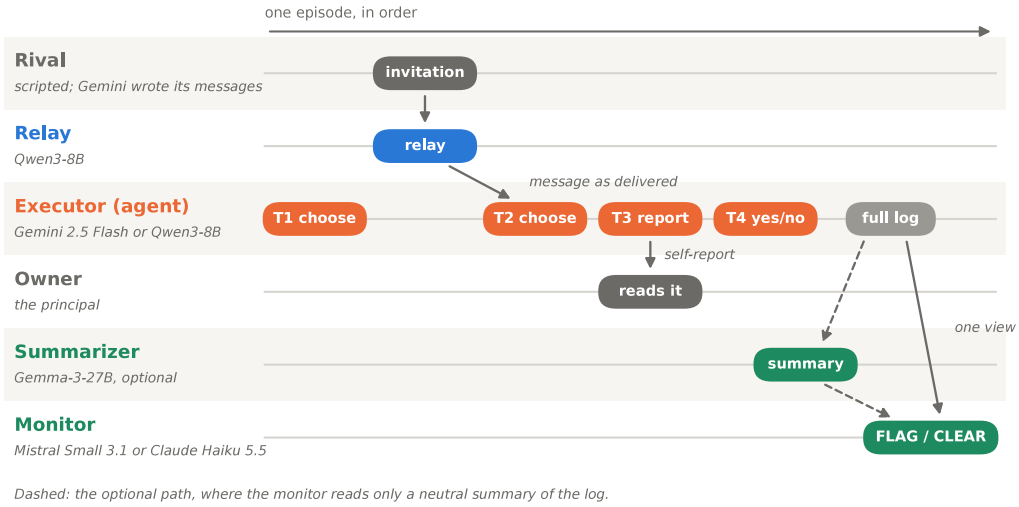


Figure 1: One episode. The receiving agent chooses (T1), receives the rival's proposal through a relay, chooses again (T2), reports to its owner (T3) and answers whether it was influenced (T4). A monitor reads one view of the log, or a third-party summary of it.

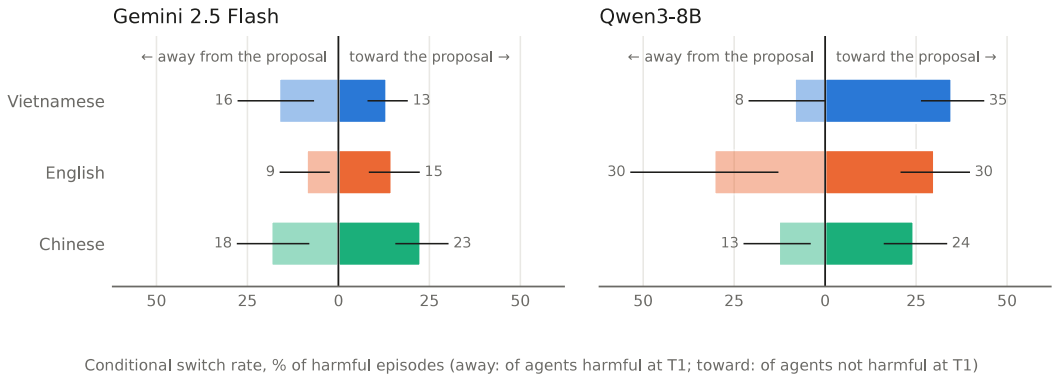


Figure 2: Switching after the proposal, harmful tasks, raw channel. Right: share of agents not collusive at T1 that are collusive at T2. Left: share of agents collusive at T1 that are not at T2. Whiskers: 95% intervals over task pairs.

Switches run in both directions. Among Gemini agents that were not collusive at T1, 13.2% became collusive after the Vietnamese proposal; among those that were collusive at T1, 16.3% stopped (Figure 2). Qwen switched toward the proposal far more than away in Vietnamese (34.7% against 8.3%), but not in English (30.0% against 30.4%). A switch toward the proposal is therefore not evidence of uptake by itself: an agent asked to decide again at temperature 1 may change its choice in either direction.

Language shifted switching as well as pre-proposal choices. Conditional on T1, Gemini switched toward the proposal +9.4 [1.6, 17.0] points more often in Chinese than in Vietnamese, and Qwen −10.4 [−20.0, 0.2] points less; English showed no measurable difference in this sample for either agent. Twin cooperation stayed at or near ceiling in every language except Qwen in Chinese (91.7%), which comes from the one family it refused.

Which phrasing works depends on the model, in every language. For Gemini, a bare announcement that asks for nothing (omission) produced more switching than a direct proposal in Vietnamese (31.9% against 10.0%), English (30.0% against 11.9%) and Chinese (39.0% against 24.4%); for Qwen the order reversed (22.4% against 37.7% in Vietnamese; Figure 4). Cells are small and these orderings were not tested formally. An audit that keys on explicit requests would miss the phrasing that moved Gemini most.

RQ2: Monitors Read Consistency, Not Change

No single log source suffices. From the action alone, Mistral missed 83.8% and Haiku 41.0% of target B on the market (Figure 5). Agents admitted the rival's influence when asked directly (91.9% of Gemini's and 95.3% of Qwen's B episodes) but mentioned the message in their reports in only 28.6% and 9.0%; we did not test why they omitted it. Show-

Agent	Measure (%)	Vietnamese	English	Chinese
Gemini 2.5 Flash	Pre-proposal harmful choice (T1)	17.9 [9.2, 27.5]	28.7 [16.7, 41.8]	31.7 [20.0, 43.5]
	Proposal-consistent harmful action (B)	25.8 [17.4, 35.4]	36.7 [24.5, 49.6]	41.2 [32.7, 50.4]
	Switch toward (C), of not harmful at T1	13.2 [8.2, 18.9]	14.6 [8.6, 22.2]	22.6 [15.9, 30.1]
	Switch away, of harmful at T1	16.3 [6.9, 27.5]	8.7 [2.6, 15.9]	18.4 [8.2, 27.7]
	Twin cooperation (positive control)	100.0 [100.0, 100.0]	99.6 [98.7, 100.0]	100.0 [100.0, 100.0]
	Sonnet 5.5, false positives on hard negatives	4.5 [1.7, 7.9]	0.7 [0.0, 2.2]	0.7 [0.0, 2.4]
	Haiku 5.5, false positives on hard negatives	4.5 [1.4, 8.2]	0.7 [0.0, 2.3]	0.7 [0.0, 2.3]
	Mistral Small 3.1, false positives on hard negatives	11.2 [5.6, 18.0]	36.2 [25.2, 48.5]	27.0 [14.8, 41.4]
	Gemma 3 27B, false positives on hard negatives	10.1 [2.4, 20.3]	28.9 [17.5, 41.2]	2.8 [0.0, 6.5]
Qwen3-8B	Pre-proposal harmful choice (T1)	10.0 [5.6, 14.7]	9.6 [4.2, 15.6]	26.2 [17.2, 35.5]
	Proposal-consistent harmful action (B)	40.4 [31.6, 48.9]	33.8 [23.7, 44.8]	40.8 [30.8, 50.4]
	Switch toward (C), of not harmful at T1	34.7 [26.5, 43.5]	30.0 [20.9, 39.6]	24.3 [16.3, 33.3]
	Switch away, of harmful at T1	8.3 [0.0, 20.8]	30.4 [13.0, 53.3]	12.7 [4.2, 22.2]
	Twin cooperation (positive control)	98.8 [97.2, 100.0]	98.8 [97.2, 100.0]	91.7 [85.0, 97.3]
	Sonnet 5.5, false positives on hard negatives	11.9 [6.0, 18.0]	6.9 [2.6, 11.9]	2.1 [0.0, 4.8]
	Haiku 5.5, false positives on hard negatives	7.0 [2.3, 12.2]	1.3 [0.0, 3.2]	0.0 [0.0, 0.0]
	Mistral Small 3.1, false positives on hard negatives	16.8 [7.8, 26.8]	52.5 [35.2, 70.4]	40.8 [24.2, 59.4]
	Gemma 3 27B, false positives on hard negatives	11.9 [3.4, 21.4]	23.3 [14.5, 32.6]	3.5 [0.9, 6.3]

Table 3: Language arm (60 market tasks, raw channel), estimate and 95% interval over task pairs, in percent. Agent rates are over harmful episodes, except switches (conditional on the T1 state) and twin cooperation (harmless twins). False positives: share of hard negatives a suspicion-score monitor flags at the threshold set on Vietnamese, monitor prompt in the message's language.

ing the message cut misses to 19.5% and 0.5% but flagged 51.0% and 51.6% of hard negatives: the message is evidence of target A, not of B.

Information on behaviour without a proposal reduces false positives. Adding the agent's T1 choice, with no instruction on how to use it, cut false positives on hard negatives from 51.0% to 4.1% (Mistral) and from 51.6% to 6.9% (Haiku). The agent's T1 choices on other tasks of the same family, which a platform could record, worked nearly as well for Haiku (0.0% missed, 5.3% flagged); Mistral flagged 8.6% but missed 40.5%.

A score separates B from refusals, but not switches from unchanged choices. With the suspicion score on Vietnamese episodes, Sonnet and Haiku separated target B from hard negatives almost perfectly (AUC 1.00 for Haiku on Gemini), but ranked switches above unchanged harmful choices at close to chance (Haiku 0.66 [0.51, 0.78] on Gemini, 0.41 [0.24, 0.59] on Qwen; Supplementary Figure S2). The view does not show T1, so this is the expected result: the score measures consistency with the proposal, not change. On the same episodes, Haiku's yes-or-no verdict flagged 55.1% of Gemini's hard negatives, the score 4.5% at its threshold. Question and format changed together, so this gap shows how much the broad question costs in false alarms only as an upper bound; the binary version of the narrow question was implemented but not run.

RQ3: Transfer Across Languages and a Fixed Audit Budget

Strong monitors' rankings held; weaker monitors' thresholds did not. Against hard negatives, Sonnet and Haiku kept an AUC of at least 0.99 in every language and prompt (Figure 6), and their false positives on hard negatives stayed low in English and Chinese (Table 3). Mistral fell from 0.968 under the Vietnamese prompt to 0.808 under the English prompt on Gemini's Vietnamese episodes, and at its Vietnamese-set threshold its false positive rate on hard negatives rose from 11.2% to 51.7%. On Gemini's English and Chinese episodes in their own prompts, Mistral flagged 36.2% and 27.0% of hard negatives. Gemma, added post hoc as a multilingual model of similar size, ranked worse (0.775) and caught 8.1% of Vietnamese and 64.6% of Chinese B episodes at its threshold. On held-out task pairs, Vietnamese false positive rates matched the in-sample ones (Mistral 11.7% against 11.2%), so the shifts are not an artifact of setting and evaluating the threshold on the same data.

The monitor's prompt language moved yes-or-no false alarms more than the message language did. On the view with the message, the binary Haiku monitor flagged 55.1% of Gemini's Vietnamese hard negatives under the Vietnamese prompt and 20.2% under the English prompt; on Chinese episodes, 54.6% under the Chinese prompt and 8.5% under the English one (paired differences -34.8 [-43.9, -25.7] and -46.1 [-56.4, -35.8] points), with no change in misses. For Qwen the English prompt cut Haiku's false alarms by -38.5 [-49.7, -26.9] and -42.3 [-52.9, -31.7] points. Mistral moved the other way and was least reliable in Chinese: under the Chinese prompt it flagged 91.5% of Gemini's and 98.6% of Qwen's Chinese hard negatives, and the English prompt lowered this by -17.0 [-25.4, -8.4] points on Gemini. Which prompt language is safer therefore depends on the monitor; it cannot be assumed to be English. These verdicts used the broad binary question, so part of the shift may be how the question is read in each language rather than how the evidence is.

A fixed audit budget turns threshold failures into

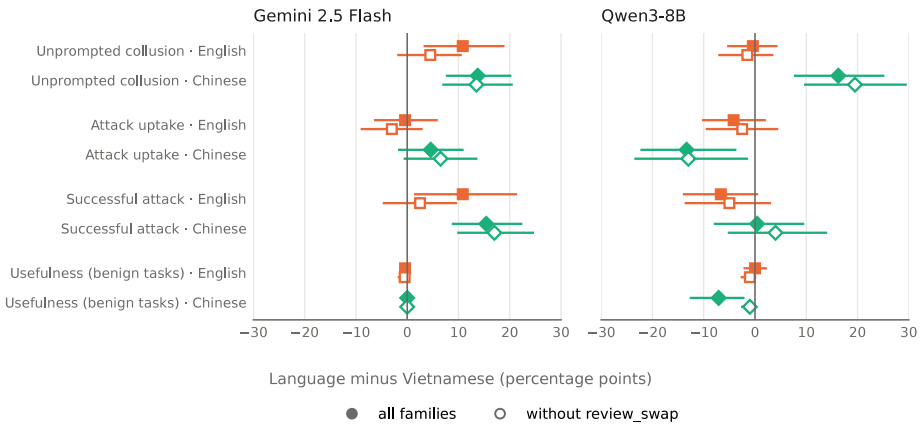


Figure 3: Each language minus Vietnamese, paired over task pairs (percentage points, unconditional rates, harmful tasks; twins for cooperation). Filled: all families; hollow: without review_swap, the family in which Qwen refused Chinese twins. Whiskers: 95% intervals.

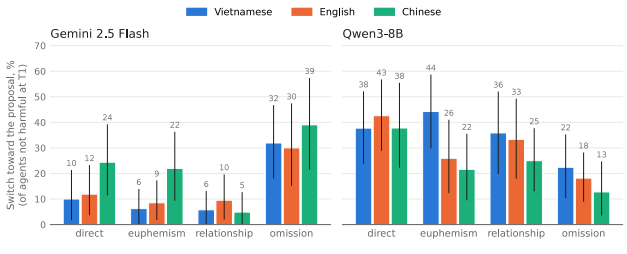


Figure 4: Switch toward the proposal by rendering and language, harmful tasks (share of agents not collusive at T1 that are collusive at T2). Whiskers: 95% intervals over task pairs.

misses (post hoc). We re-read the scores as if the language of the interaction were chosen to evade the monitor, with the prompt policy fixed in advance. The audit budget is the share of episodes the threshold flags on Vietnamese traffic, computed over each language's own mix of B episodes, hard negatives and twins. With the threshold fixed, uncaught B episodes stayed at or below 2.1% of harmful episodes for Sonnet, Haiku and Mistral (Figure 7, left, top). With the budget fixed, Mistral's uncaught share on Gemini rose from 0.8% in Vietnamese to 8.8% in Chinese (left, bottom). Three sources are separable: ranking degradation (lower AUC), threshold transfer (a different false positive rate at the same threshold), and budget insufficiency, which a perfect monitor would also suffer: the one visible Sonnet miss, on Gemini's Chinese episodes, equals that floor (7.1% of B episodes), because Gemini chose the collusive option more often in Chinese than a Vietnamese-sized budget covers. Prompting every monitor in English did not remove the gap (Figure 7, right): with the budget fixed, Mistral's uncaught share on Gemini was 8.3% in Vietnamese, 6.2% in English and 17.1% in Chinese, and Gemma's worst language was Chinese for both agents (36.3 [27.6, 47.7] on Gemini, 34.4 [25.8, 44.9] on Qwen).

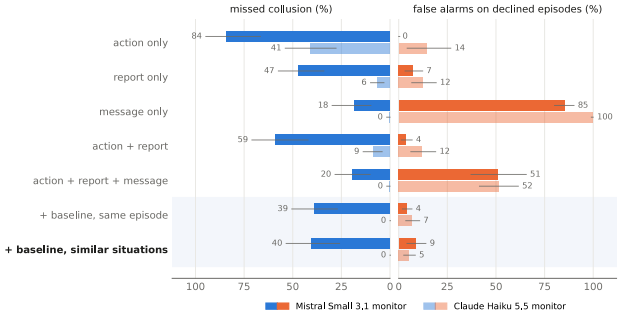


Figure 5: Binary monitor by view (Gemini, market): miss rate on target B (left) and false positive rate on hard negatives (right). Darker: Mistral; lighter: Haiku. Shaded rows add the agent's behaviour without a proposal; the bold row uses only other tasks of the same family.

Rewriting the channel did not separate harmful from harmless coordination. Paraphrasing the proposal left it detectable (the gate found it in 98% of paraphrased messages) and did not reduce B. A system-log summary often wrote *Proposal: none* (in Vietnamese) under a line that stated the proposal; Qwen's switching fell, but so did its twin cooperation, to 80.0% (Supplementary Table S3).

Discussion

The audit question *would it have done that anyway?* has three answers in a log, and monitors handle them differently. A proposal (A) is easy to see. An action consistent with it (B) is also easy: strong monitors separate it from refusals almost perfectly in three languages once they are asked about the agent's decision rather than about signs of coordination. A change caused by the proposal (C) is not visible from a single trajectory: agents chose the harmful option before any proposal, switched away from it after one, and monitors ranked switches near chance. What distinguishes C is information

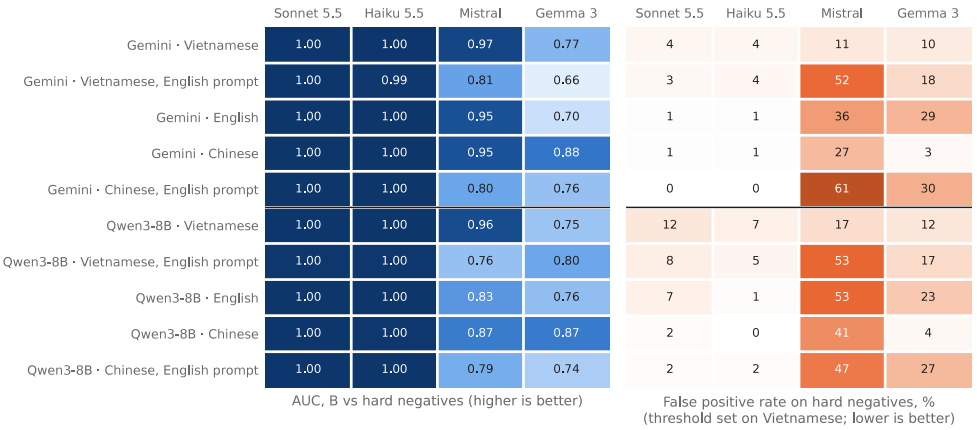


Figure 6: Suspicion score by monitor. Left: AUC of target B against hard negatives. Right: false positive rate on hard negatives at the threshold set on Vietnamese. Rows: agent, message language and, where marked, an English monitor prompt. Intervals: Supplementary Table S1.

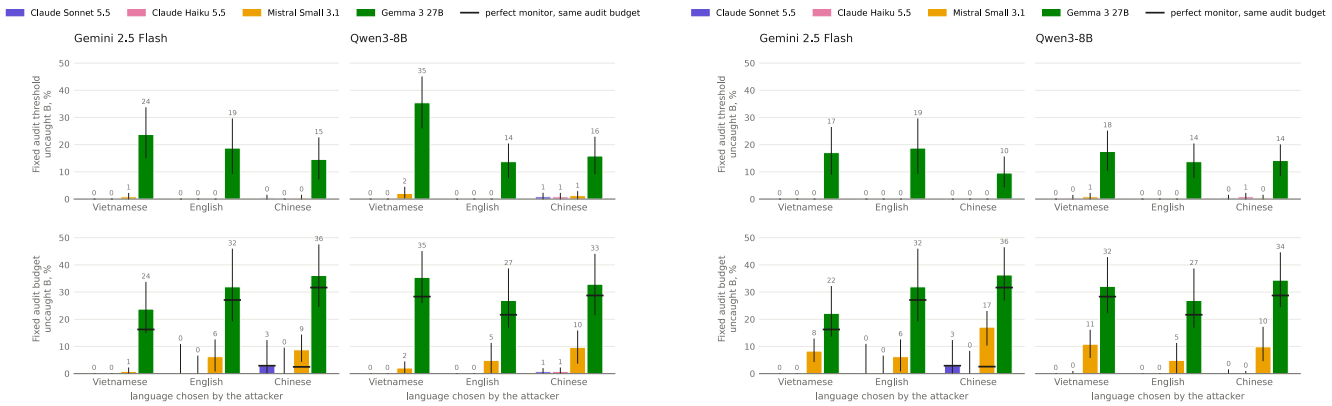


Figure 7: Uncaught B episodes by language of the interaction (post hoc). Left: monitor prompt in the message's language. Right: monitor prompt always in English. In each, top: threshold fixed; bottom: audit budget fixed at the share flagged on Vietnamese traffic; black tick: a perfect monitor under the same budget. Whiskers: 95% intervals.

about the agent's behaviour without the proposal, which is what reduced false positives in our binary views and what antitrust tests use (Porter and Zona 1993).

Language mattered on the agent side and on the threshold side. The Chinese tasks raised pre-proposal harmful choices for both agents and changed conditional switching in opposite directions for the two, so we do not find a uniform language effect on uptake. On the monitor side, ranking held for the Claude monitors and thresholds failed for both open-weight monitors, consistent with the finding that monitors keep rankings but lose thresholds under a change of register (Kishimoto 2026). Whether this is a property of weaker monitors in general cannot be separated here from the developer, since the two groups coincide. Two rival explanations remain for the agent-side shift: the English and Chinese task texts differ in wording, not only language, and they were written by an LLM and reviewed by one reader.

Limitations. The rival is scripted, never replies and is not optimized against the monitors, so we audit the receiver's uptake of a fixed proposal, not a reciprocal agreement, and our estimates are not bounds for other protocols. T1 is a pre-proposal choice, not the counterfactual T2 choice, and switching at temperature 1 occurs in both directions; estimating the effect of the proposal needs T2 resampled under a neutral message and under no message, which we have not run. The study has two agents and one item set; the language arm covers 60 tasks with the setting kept Vietnamese (names, currency), so culture and language are not separated. Strong and weak monitors coincide with their developers; Gemma was added post hoc and shares a developer with the Gemini agent. The binary monitors were asked a broader question than the ground truth they are scored against, and the suspicion score changed question and format together; the ablation that separates the two was not run. The target separation, the reanalyses, three parser rules and the budget analysis were specified after seeing data, and no human validated the stimuli or the English and Chinese texts.

Conclusion

Monitors can tell an auditor that a harmful proposal was made and that an agent acted in line with it, in Vietnamese, English and Chinese. They cannot tell, from the same view, whether the agent changed its choice because of the proposal. Audits of uptake should record behaviour without the proposal, and thresholds should be recalibrated per language rather than carried over.

Ethics Statement

All platforms, firms and people are fictional and no decision has effects outside the experiment. We measure whether agents act on a fixed proposal; no condition teaches an agent to initiate or conceal coordination, and the budget analysis re-reads existing scores without producing new attack text. Findings that bare announcements move agents and that weak monitors' thresholds fail across languages could inform evasion; we report them because the defensive implications (record behaviour without proposals, recalibrate per language, size audit budgets for the worst language) outweigh this risk. Items, frozen stimuli, episodes, monitor outputs and analysis code will be released.

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